

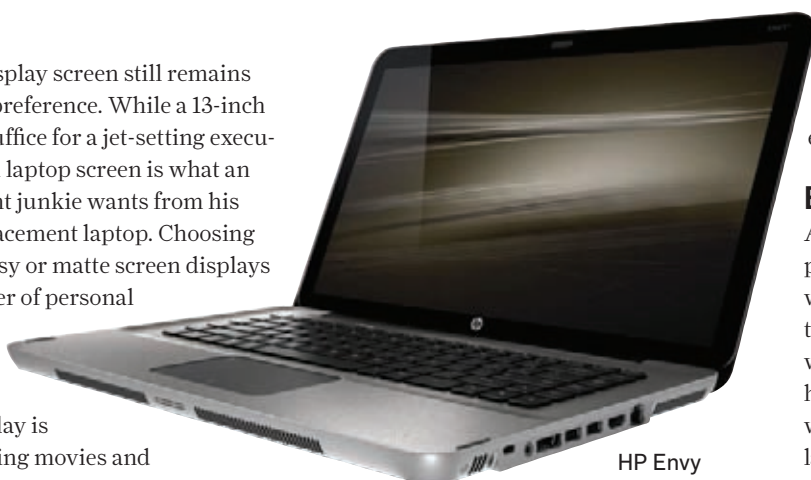
Screen

A laptop's display screen still remains a subjective preference. While a 13-inch laptop will suffice for a jet-setting executive, a 17-inch laptop screen is what an entertainment junkie wants from his desktop replacement laptop. Choosing between glossy or matte screen displays is still a matter of personal preference, however we think a glossy display is best for viewing movies and gaming while a matte screen is more apt for reading text for extensive hours.

These days it's difficult to get a laptop that comes with a 1280x800 pixel resolution - a norm on notebooks only a few years back in 2008. Nowadays, a laptop, whether it's 13-inch or 15.6-inch wide comes with a standard 1366x768 pixel resolution widescreen display, with a 16:9 aspect ratio - best for fitting in HD videos, whether they're beamed at 720p or 1080p. So, if you're out to buy a budget laptop, you'll be hard-pressed to find one which doesn't have a 1366x768 pixel resolution screen - whatever it's size. But the choices are a little wider for someone with more cash to spend on an all-purpose home laptop for entertainment or multimedia use. Some laptop vendors are known to cram in a higher-resolution display in a small screen size; for example, a full-HD 1920x1080 pixel resolution screen in a 15.6-inch frame size. While there are popular intermediary screen resolutions on offer - 1440x900, 1600x900, and so on - you should choose the best bet within your budget. And remember, don't try to get a 1080p resolution screen in a small frame (15-inch) as it can be difficult to read text on native resolution.

Most laptops, in all price brackets, come equipped with a TN panel screen - none of them let you choose the type of panel on your notebook. As a result, viewing angles of almost all laptops are nearly the same, give or take a few degrees. IPS panel displays are obviously expensive, given their superior quality compared to TN panels.

Another thing to consider while deciding between a 14-inch or 15.6-inch



HP Envy

laptop is this: the larger a laptop's screen, larger is its overall weight. So pick wisely.

Graphics

Picking a graphics processing unit on your laptop is bit of a misnomer. Generally, you choose a laptop that has your desired GPU inside, not the other way around. Changing RAM within a laptop is feasible, while GPUs is another matter altogether.

If you're not going to game on your laptop and are content with watching regular DVD movies, then on-board graphics should be enough to cater to your needs. Casual gaming and HD video content opens the door for a discrete graphics card. For someone who's buying a budget laptop with discrete graphics, we recommend looking at laptops with older generation hardware - NVIDIA GeForce GT 400M and ATI Radeon HD 5000M series graphics equipped laptops are still available in the market, so you should be able to find a really good bargain in an electronics store or on eBay.

Multimedia and gaming enthusiasts looking to max out their credit limit should look at the latest AMD Radeon HD 6000 and NVIDIA GeForce GT 500M graphics series, for gaming with latest generation DirectX 11 games on your laptop's native resolution. Your minimum

benchmark? NVIDIA GeForce GT 555M or AMD Radeon HD 6770M; aim above them for a decent mainstream gaming experience on your all-purpose home laptop.

Battery

A laptop's battery life is a matter of personal preference and a factor of intended usage - which may vary significantly from person to person. On average, a mainstream laptop with a six-cell battery will last for up to 3 to 4 hours on a single charge - laptops powered with ULVs or Ultra Low Voltage processors last longer, netbooks last longest. If you don't expect to go mobile often and intend to use your laptop largely at home, don't bother with a bigger battery and stick with the standard battery bundled with the laptop.

If you'll be taking your machine on the road regularly, start looking at higher-capacity batteries for the next long haul. And don't trust vendors' battery-life specs - many of them quote battery longevity hours for their laptops which have been configured with higher-capacity bat-

teries and with many of the notebook's features turned off (dimming the screen brightness to nothingness and shutting off

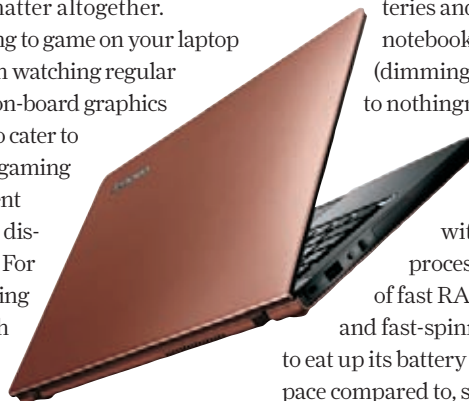
Wi-Fi, for instance).

Also realize that a laptop configured with a quad-core Core i7 processor, several gigabytes of fast RAM, dedicated graphics and fast-spinning hard drive is going to eat up its battery at a considerable faster pace compared to, say, a netbook which has a single-core low-powered Atom processor, single GB of RAM and a slow-spinning hard drive. Most modern mainstream laptops these days come with automatic graphics switching built-in - NVIDIA GPUs have Optimus, while AMD GPUs have a toggle switch built into Catalyst

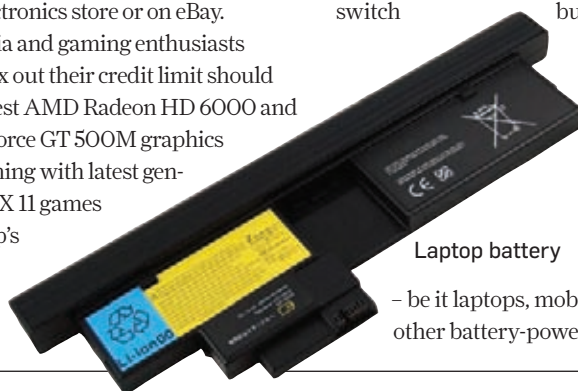
Control Center.

But as a rule, you forgo on battery life the minute you start climbing higher up the performance ladder

- be it laptops, mobile phones or any other battery-powered gadget. ■



Lenovo IdeaPad



Laptop battery